

TWO OPENINGS

Two ways of starting the same episode of a true crime podcast. Each is about a minute read aloud.

Please have them read to you rather than reading them yourself, in whichever order you are given, and sit with each one for a few seconds before saying anything.

A

A tone. A recorded message begins.

RECORDING. *A woman, quiet, close to the phone.* The woman they found under Stonebridge had a name. It was Kerry. She didn't fall down those steps. He told me she hit her head in her own room and that he moved her afterwards. That's never been in the news.

A door opens somewhere behind her. Keys.

A MAN, distant. Leah?

RECORDING. I have to go.

The message ends.

ALLY. I played that back eleven times. On the eleventh I said "where are you" out loud, in an empty studio, at one in the morning, to a woman who had recorded it four hours earlier and was not there.

Our tip line keeps three things. A voice, a date, a time. It doesn't keep numbers, because I promised it wouldn't, and that promise is the only reason anybody uses it.

So Tuesday night left me with a dead woman who has no surname, a living woman who has no address, and a man who has probably already looked at her phone.

B

ALLY. It took me two days to find somebody who might be missing a Kerry.

Her name is Maureen Nolan. She lives interstate, and she has paid her daughter's phone bill every month since November. The number rings out. She leaves messages anyway. She told me they have all turned into the same message by now, which is that she isn't angry and she would just like to know she's all right.

Her daughter has been dead since November.

She is in a file in this city under five words. Unidentified female, no fixed address. Found at the bottom of the steps under the Stonebridge Viaduct with one injury to the back of her head, and this city wrote down that she fell.

Here is what I actually have. On Tuesday night a woman I have never met left a message saying Kerry didn't fall, that she hit her head in a room and that a man carried her out afterwards. Then somebody in the corridor said her name and she hung up.

I don't know if she was telling me the truth.

I know that if she was, she is sleeping tonight beside the man who did it, and I have no idea where that is.

Two questions

1. **Which one do you need to hear the rest of?**
2. **Would you come back tomorrow for it?**

If you want to say more, say it after you have answered those two. First instinct is the useful thing.